CYBER, AI ARMOUR TO SECURE INDIA'S GEOPOLITICAL STRATEGY

Dr (Prof) Nishakant Ojha, is among India's eminent experts in cyber crime and anti-terrorism strategy, whose advise is widely sought after on matters pertaining to policy-making, security and safety of India and counter-terrorism issues of West Asia & Middle East. He earned the monikers- "Strategy Man" and "Soldier without Uniform".



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- **That integration of intelligence agencies will prove to be a formidable strength to counter and destroy terrorism. What's your take on it?**

  In today's troubled world, the nation's security challenges have gone beyond military threats or terrorism, spanning a wide range of threats across all warfare domains including land, sea, air, nuclear, space, cyber, and energy resources. They also involve demographic changes, financial laundering, and narco-terrorism. Internal security threats arise from societal instability caused by communal, sectarian, and caste-based conflicts.

  It is crucial for India to thoroughly evaluate whether its intelligence agencies are properly structured and equipped to foresee and counter numerous threats pose to India's security, both external and internal. One critical area is the strategic assessment of foreign intelligence capabilities for which timely and institutionalized reviews must be held for its intelligence structures, besides implementing transformative reforms.

- **How is India manoeuvring rapidly shifting Geo politics supported by your strategic mission roles in Middle East countries?**

  The geopolitical landscape of the Middle East has undergone significant shifts in recent years, posing challenges for India, especially in the light of Modi government's "Link West" policy aimed at enhancing cooperation with the region. India has achieved considerable success in strengthening ties with the Middle East, with some of the regional changes fostering closer relations that align with the Link West policy. Chabahar Port –Tehran, is one such strategic victory for India and specially for me , nevertheless, the fluctuating stability in the Middle East remains a serious concern

- **What is your roadmap for strengthening India's autonomous warfare?**

  The global autonomous weapons market is projected to grow to $30,168.14 million by 2030. Countries like the U.S., China, Russia, South Korea, France, Germany, the UK, Sweden, and Italy are developing autonomous military robotic systems. The preparedness of Indian defence forces for modern conflicts in various terrains along the Indo-Pak, Indo-Tibetan, and Indo-Sino borders, is a critical area for analysis. India is acquiring advanced technologies like artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning, and sensor technologies to enhance its autonomous warfare capabilities. The focus is on developing systems that can function in diverse environments and execute complex missions with minimal human intervention. Emphasis areas include integration and collaboration with industry and academia.

- **How can AI and Next-Gen technologies improve cyber and aerospace capabilities, besides a proper audit system for effective outcomes?**

  The aerospace industry encompasses various aspects of development, manufacturing, maintenance, and support of aircraft, spacecraft, and rotorcraft.

  Traditionally, aerospace has struggled to keep pace with the latest technology trends due to lengthy regulatory cycles. However, implementing Artificial Intelligence (AI) can address the challenges by ensuring that the AI algorithms are highly intelligent and reliable. AI is also effective in cyber defence, where logs of recorded activities from servers and network components can be labelled as "hostile" or "non-hostile."

  One of the important concerns is the absence of a Dedicated Regulatory Body under the Government of India for auditing technologies, and a clear SOP to evaluate their appropriateness for the right applications and costs.

- **What are the advantages of Defence PSU's promoting Defence export?**

  India's defense export status has improved significantly in recent years making it a leading exporter of defense equipment to friendly nations, yet there have been missed opportunities.

  India has successfully exported personal protective items, offshore patrol vessels, and avionics to countries like the Maldives, Sri Lanka, Russia, France, Nepal, Mauritius etc. However, there is a need for dedicated export infrastructure, including training, support, and market intelligence systems.

  Additionally, PSUs involved in international business should focus on strategic development for India rather than merely handling documentation. The defence sector needs a dedicated Export Promotion Council, enhance R&D infrastructure, and the Department of Defence Production must explore joint or co-development opportunities with other countries.

- **What is 'Weaponization of Climate Change' by enemy countries?**

  Climate change is escalating global security challenges with the potential for increased military involvement. Its effects, such as food and water shortages, infrastructure damage, and mass displacement, raise the risk of conflicts. Additionally, more severe natural disasters can lead to humanitarian crises and disrupt supply chains. The military might be required to address these issues, besides be involved in establishing new bases or protecting critical energy resources like oil and gas. China's plan to develop a large-scale weather modification system by 2025 has raised concerns, especially among its neighbouring countries.